Chicken Fricassee

Bone-in chicken thighs are browned in butter, then braised in a pale roux-thickened sauce with cremini mushrooms, onion, and garlic. Dry white wine and chicken stock build the base; heavy cream finishes the sauce until silky and pale. Serve over egg noodles, mashed potatoes, or rice. Serves 4–6.

Ingredients

Chicken thighs, bone-in, skin-on . . . . . 8 (3 lb.)
Kosher salt and black pepper . . . . . as needed
Unsalted butter . . . . . 4 Tbsp.
Cremini mushrooms . . . . . 10 oz.
Yellow onion . . . . . 2 medium
Garlic cloves 3
Bay leaf 1
Dried thyme . . . . . 1 tsp.
All-purpose flour . . . . . 3 Tbsp.
Dry white wine . . . . . 1/2 cup
Chicken stock . . . . . 3 cups
Heavy cream . . . . . 2/3 cup
Dried parsley . . . . . 1 tsp.
Nutmeg . . . . . pinch

Directions

Pat **chicken thighs** dry and season generously with **salt** and **black pepper** — Slice **cremini mushrooms**; set aside in *Medium Bowl #1* (mushrooms) — Dice **yellow onions** and mince **garlic**; combine in *Small Bowl #1* (aromatics) — Measure **dried thyme**, **bay leaf**, **flour**, **white wine**, **chicken stock**, **heavy cream**, **dried parsley**, and **nutmeg**

1. Heat a large Dutch oven or deep skillet over medium-high heat. Melt 2 Tbsp. **butter** until foaming subsides. Working in batches if needed to avoid crowding, add **chicken thighs** skin-side down and brown for *4–5 minutes* until skin is deep golden and releases easily from the pan. Flip and brown the second side for *3–4 minutes* until lightly golden. Transfer **chicken** to *Large Bowl #1* and set aside.

2. Reduce heat to medium-high. Add 1 Tbsp. **butter** to the pot. Add sliced **cremini mushrooms** (*Medium Bowl #1*) and cook, stirring occasionally, for *12–15 minutes*. They will release a pool of liquid first, then dry out and begin to brown as that moisture evaporates. Continue until mushrooms are deeply browned, the pan looks dry, and edges look crisp at the rim. Transfer cooked **mushrooms** back to *Medium Bowl #1* and set aside.

3. Reduce heat to medium. Add remaining 1 Tbsp. **butter**. Add diced **onion** (*Small Bowl #1*), **bay leaf**, and 1 tsp. **dried thyme**. Cook, stirring often, for *10–12 minutes* until **onion** is translucent and fully softened, edges are lightly golden, and the pieces feel tender when pressed with a spatula. If **onion**

browns too quickly, lower heat slightly and add a splash of **chicken stock** to slow cooking. Add minced **garlic** (*Small Bowl #1*) and cook for *1–2 minutes* more until fragrant without browning.

4. Sprinkle 3 Tbsp. **flour** evenly over the **onion** mixture and stir constantly for *2 minutes* until the roux smells nutty and toasty and no dry flour remains. The paste should look smooth and pale gold. If roux clumps, press and stir vigorously with a wooden spoon until smooth. Reduce heat to medium-low if the roux darkens too fast.

5. Pour in 1/2 cup **dry white wine**, scraping the bottom of the pot to dissolve browned bits. Simmer for *2–3 minutes*, stirring, until the wine reduces slightly and the harsh alcohol smell fades. The liquid should look glossy and lightly thickened at the edges.

6. Whisk in 3 cups **chicken stock** until smooth. Return **chicken** (*Large Bowl #1*) to the pot skin-side up. Bring to a gentle simmer, taste the liquid, and season with **salt** and **black pepper** as needed. Cover and simmer over low heat for *15 minutes*, then uncover and continue simmering for *18–22 minutes* until **chicken** is fall-apart tender, meat pulls easily from the bone, and the thickest part registers *165°F* on an instant-read thermometer. Continue simmering in *3–5 minute* increments if the center is still pink or firm.

7. Transfer **chicken** back to *Large Bowl #1* and tent loosely with foil to keep warm. Stir 2/3 cup **heavy cream**, 1 tsp. **dried parsley**, and a pinch of **nutmeg** into the sauce. Simmer gently over medium-low heat for *3–5 minutes*, stirring, until the sauce is silky, pale ivory, and coats the back of a spoon (a line drawn through it with your finger should hold clearly). Taste and adjust **salt**, **black pepper**, and **nutmeg** as needed. If the sauce breaks or looks greasy, remove from heat and whisk vigorously until smooth. If too thin, simmer uncovered for another *2–3 minutes*.

8. Return cooked **mushrooms** (*Medium Bowl #1*) and **chicken** (*Large Bowl #1*) to the sauce. Warm over low heat for *2–3 minutes*, spooning sauce over the **chicken**, until everything is hot throughout. Discard the **bay leaf**. Serve immediately while the sauce is glossy and the **chicken** is tender.

Equipment Required

- Large Dutch oven or deep skillet with lid (6-quart preferred)
- Wooden spoon or spatula
- Whisk
- Instant-read thermometer
- Large prep bowl (1)
- Medium prep bowl (1)
- Small prep bowl (1)
- Cutting board and chef's knife
- Measuring cups and spoons

Hints and Notes

Yield

- Serves 4–6 (8 bone-in thighs with generous sauce).

Mise en Place

- **Small Bowl #1** — aromatics: diced **yellow onion** and minced **garlic** (onion added in step 3 first; garlic added after *10–12 minutes*)
- **Medium Bowl #1** — sliced **cremini mushrooms**; holds cooked mushrooms after step 2
- **Large Bowl #1** — browned then braised **chicken thighs**
- Measure 1 tsp. **dried thyme**, 1 tsp. **dried parsley**, 3 Tbsp. **flour**, ½ cup **white wine**, 3 cups **chicken stock**, ⅔ cup **heavy cream**, and a pinch of **nutmeg**
- Pat **chicken** dry before browning; surface moisture inhibits browning and dilutes the fond

Ingredient Tips

- **Chicken thighs**: bone-in, skin-on thighs braise best and stay moist. Skin-on pieces also render fat that enriches the sauce.
- **Cremini mushrooms**: deeper flavor than white button mushrooms. Quarter or thickly slice so they brown instead of steaming.
- **Dry white wine**: Pinot Grigio, Sauvignon Blanc, or unoaked Chardonnay add acidity without sweetness. Avoid sweet or oaked wines that muddy the pale sauce.
- **Dried herbs**: 1 tsp. **dried thyme** replaces about 3 fresh sprigs. **Dried parsley** is milder than fresh; add at the finish so its flavor stays in the sauce.
- **Chicken stock**: low-sodium stock gives more control over salting. Homemade stock deepens flavor further.

Preparation Tips

- **Browning**: do not crowd the pot. Crowded **chicken** steams instead of browning and leaves a thin fond. Work in two batches if your Dutch oven is smaller than 6-quart.
- **Mushrooms**: expect a wet phase before browning begins. Cook the full *12–15 minutes* until the pan is dry and the mushrooms are deeply browned. Wet mushrooms make a watery sauce when returned at the end.
- **Onions**: give diced **onion** the full *10–12 minutes* to soften and sweeten before adding **garlic**. Adding **garlic** earlier risks burning it during the longer sweat.
- **Roux**: cook the flour fully before adding liquid. A raw-flour taste means the roux needed more time; continue stirring over medium-low heat until nutty.
- **Braise**: keep the simmer gentle after uncovering. A rolling boil tightens **chicken** and can break the cream-finished sauce.
- **Cream finish**: add **heavy cream** after the **chicken** is cooked through. High heat after dairy goes in can cause curdling.

Make Ahead & Storage

- Flavor improves after an overnight rest in the refrigerator. Cool completely, then refrigerate up to *3 days*.
- Reheat gently on the stovetop over low heat, stirring and adding a splash of **chicken stock** or **cream** if the sauce has thickened.
- Freeze up to *2 months* without the **cream** finish for best texture; stir in **cream** when reheating.
- Peak moment is right off the stove, when the sauce is glossy and **chicken** is fall-apart tender.

Serving Suggestions

- Serve over egg noodles, mashed potatoes, or rice.
- Spoon the sauce generously over the **chicken** and mushrooms at the table.
- Crusty bread works well for soaking up any sauce left in the bowl.